Starting work with a disability

Completing your studies well, finding a suitable job and pursuing your career with motivation is not always easy. TUM Alumni Jürgen Schopp and Markus Fleischmann have mastered these career steps while also dealing with physical impairments. How they dealt with this in their studies and professional life and what tips they have for people with impairments, can be read in the following portraits.

"Handle your disability however you feel most comfortable"

Markus Fleischmann

Bachelor's degree in Management and Technology 2016, Master's in 2019, Senior IT Consultant at Syna GmbH

Markus Fleischmann did not find his short right arm an impairment in any way during his studies or while searching for a job. It was the unique combination of Business and Informatics – the topics that interested him most – that led Markus Fleischmann to choose Management and Technology at TUM. He thoroughly enjoyed his time here, especially because two semesters abroad in Finland and the Netherlands were made possible for him. He also spent a year as a working student on the TUM: Junge Akademie scholarship program. "The diverse and varied work at TUMJA taught me a lot, gave me a great deal of joy and helped me to mature as a person," he recalls. Fleischmann came to his current position through his previous employment as an IT consultant at a

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Canadian software manufacturer. In that role, he supported and implemented numerous projects for the Syna/Süwag Group, which moved to secure his services as a Senior IT Consultant one year later. His physical impairment does not affect his work in his current role, either. “At the Syna/Süwag Group, we have a disability officer I can turn to for anything I need,” says Markus Fleischmann. “But I have never had cause to contact them.” In fact, Markus Fleischmann has never had a job interview where he had the impression that his impairment was a decisive criterion. He has some advice for young students with similar impairments searching for a job and entering the working world: “Be open and honest: handle your disability however you feel most comfortable. There’s no one-size-fits-all approach because each impairment is unique, just as each one of us is unique.”

“It was always about my abilities, not my impairment”

Jürgen Schopp

Master’s degree in Landscape Architecture and Landscape Planning 1996,
Director of the Geoinformation department at the Verband Region Stuttgart

Jürgen Schopp has been almost completely deaf since birth. He has been reliant on lip-reading and hearing aids from a young age. Today, he uses cochlea implants, which were implanted under the skin behind his ears. “For many years, I felt as though I had to prove myself in the hearing world,” he says. Over the years, however, he found that he would be judged by those around him based on his professional and personal capabilities, just like anyone else.

After training as a gardener specializing in Horticulture and Landscape Gardening, Schopp studied Landscape Architecture and Landscape Planning at TUM. Initially, he worried about whether he would be able to cope with this challenging degree program given his hearing impairment. However, equipped with a personal radio transmission device in addition to his hearing aids, Schopp was able to follow the lectures and seminars at TUM well, including in acoustically challenging situations. To this day, he remains grateful for the support shown by his fellow students and the staff in his department, including his professors. “It was always about my abilities, not my impairment,” he says. “As a student and research assistant, I was always taken seriously at TUM. These activities were crucial milestones for me.”

Despite receiving two offers for doctoral study, he decided to deepen his understanding of geographical information systems. He also completed an UNIGIS distance learning course, earning the title of Master of Advanced Studies in Geoinformatics from the University of Salzburg. For the last 25 years, he has worked for the Verband Region Stuttgart, an association of local authorities within the Stuttgart region. As an expert in geographical information systems, he does his part to promote the sustainable development of his native region. He has headed the department since 2006.

Link to alumni story:
www.community.tum.de/en/juergen-schopp

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